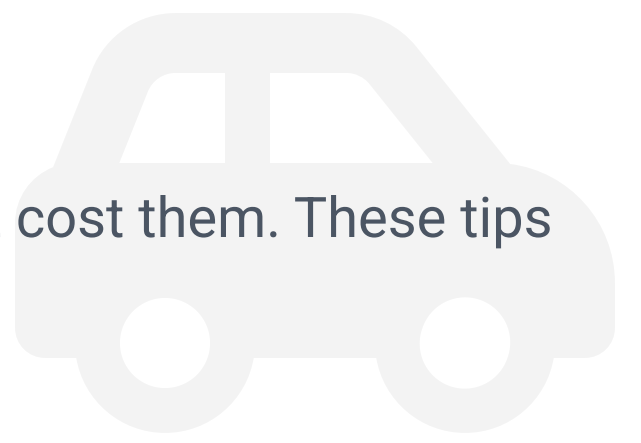


5 Things to Look Out For Before Buying a Car



Buying a car is a big move — but many buyers miss simple red flags that cost them. These tips help you avoid common traps and stay sharp before signing anything.



What Interest Rates Might Be Too High for Your Credit Profile

Interest rates vary based on your credit score — and not all lenders offer the same deal. A **higher score usually qualifies for a lower rate**, but some finance companies still charge more than they should. Always compare offers from multiple lenders and understand what your monthly payments look like across different terms. Don't just accept the first number you're given — shop it around.



How to Do a Quick Vehicle Diagnostic Before You Buy

You don't need to be a mechanic to get a good sense of a car's condition. Here are a few quick checks:

- Bring an OBD-II scanner (many cost less than \$25) to check for hidden engine codes.
- Pop the hood and check fluid levels and cleanliness.
- Test drive the car: listen for unusual sounds, vibrations, or pulling.
- Turn the AC, heater, and all electronics on/off.
- Ask for a recent inspection or maintenance record — and read it.



Why You Should Check How Many Years the Loan Really Covers

A lot of buyers focus only on the price of the car — but the **length of the loan can dramatically affect what you pay overall**. Make sure you ask:

- How many months is this loan for?
- What's the interest rate?
- What's the total amount I'll pay by the end of the loan?

A car that looks like a \$12,000 deal might end up costing \$17,000 once everything's added in. Don't just sign based on monthly payments — ask for the full breakdown.



How to Research the Dealer Before Signing Anything

A dealership might look good on the surface, but it pays to dig deeper:

- Look them up on Google and Yelp — check for patterns in reviews.
- Search their name with terms like "complaint," "scam," or "BBB."
- Ask people in your community or online forums about their experience.
- Check how long they've been in business — fly-by-night lots are risky.

If anything feels rushed, unclear, or pressured — **walk away**.



Have You Checked What Your Insurance Will Actually Cost?

Many buyers forget to calculate insurance into their monthly costs. Some vehicles — even if they're used — cost much more to insure due to risk factors, parts cost, or your location.

Before buying, get a quick quote from your current insurer (or use an online comparison tool) for the exact make and model you're considering. **Add that into your overall cost**, so you're not caught off guard later.